Echmatocrinus

ECK-mat-oh-crine-us

- **When** 505 million years ago (Middle Cambrian)
- **Fossil location** Canada
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** 1 in (3 cm) wide, below the tentacles

Echmatocrinus lived attached to the seafloor, its cone-shaped body topped by a ring of 7–9 tentacles, each bearing small side-branches. The surface of the main cone was covered with a jigsaw of hard, protective plates. When it was first discovered, scientists thought *Echmatocrinus* might be related to starfish, but it lacks the five-sided symmetry of the starfish family. Some experts think it might instead be a kind of coral.

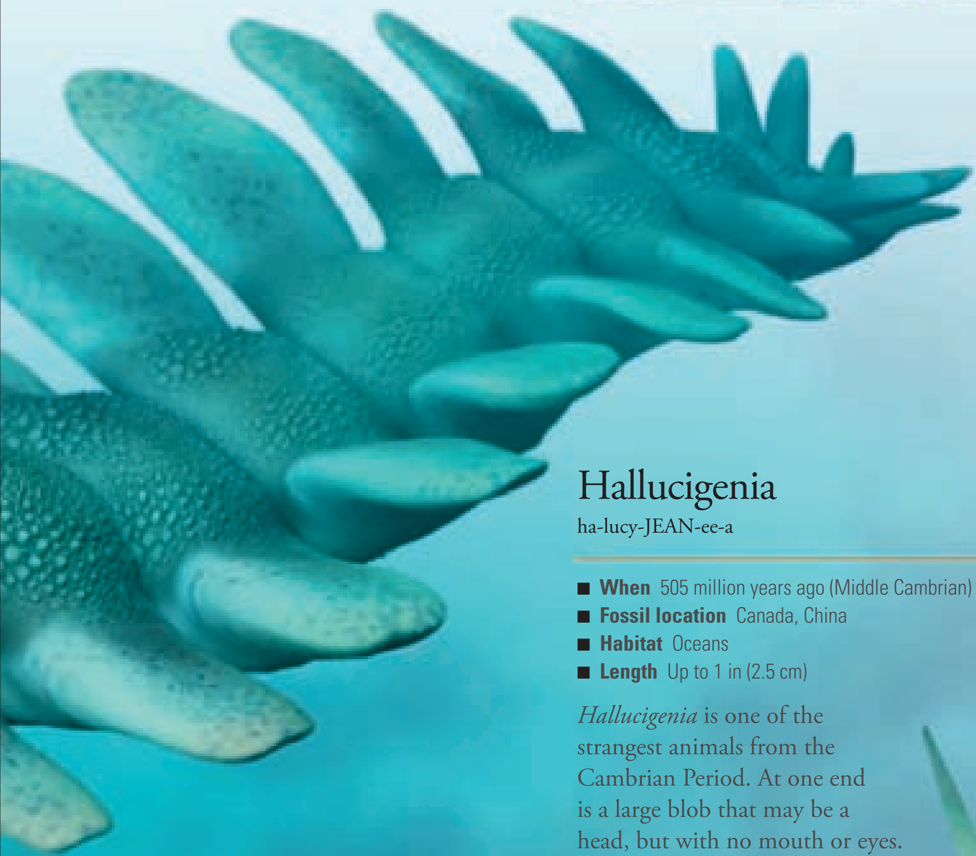
Ottoia

ot-OY-ah

- **When** 505 million years ago (Middle Cambrian) to now
- **Fossil location** Canada
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** 1½–3¼ in (4–8 cm)

Ottoia was a kind of worm that lived in U-shaped burrows, which is why its fossils are usually curved. Its mouth was covered with tiny hooks and could be turned inside out like a sock to capture small animals from the muddy seafloor. Fossilized food remains inside *Ottoia*'s gut reveal that it was a cannibal, preying on its own kind as well as devouring small shelled animals. *Ottoia* is one of the most common early Cambrian fossils, with around 1,500 known specimens.

Ottoia **fossil**

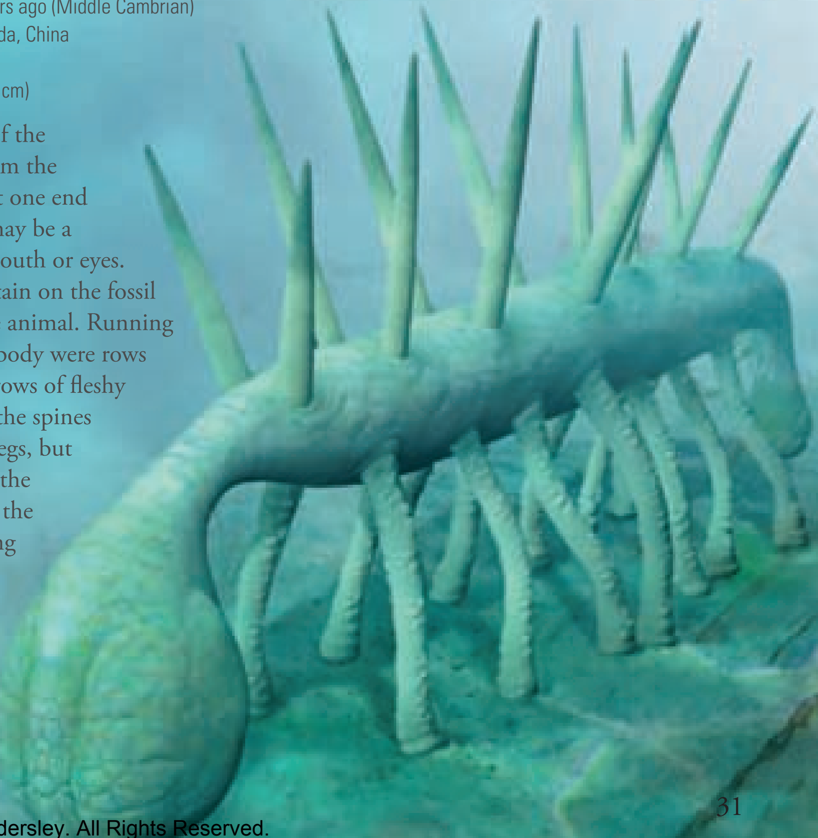


Hallucigenia

ha-lucy-JEAN-ee-a

- **When** 505 million years ago (Middle Cambrian)
- **Fossil location** Canada, China
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** Up to 1 in (2.5 cm)

Hallucigenia is one of the strangest animals from the Cambrian Period. At one end is a large blob that may be a head, but with no mouth or eyes. It may simply be a stain on the fossil and not a part of the animal. Running along the wormlike body were rows of sharp spines and rows of fleshy tentacles. Orginally the spines were thought to be legs, but scientists now think the fleshy tentacles were the legs, despite not being arranged in pairs.



DID YOU KNOW...?

All the fossils on these two pages come from the Burgess Shale Formation in the Rocky Mountains in Canada. Littering the ground at this famous mountaintop site are hundreds of beautifully preserved animal fossils dating back almost to the very dawn of animal life. The Burgess Shale contains imprints of soft body parts that normally don't fossilize and reveals that invertebrate life was already amazingly varied half a billion years ago.